Stop Pretending

By Sonya Sones

My Whole Family

(Pg 3) I can
remember what
things were like before she
got sick: my whole family climbed
into

the big
hammock on the
moondappled beach, wove
ourselves together, and swayed
as one.

INTRODUCTION

It happens just like that, in the blink of an eye. An older sister has a mental breakdown and has to be hospitalized. A younger sister is left behind to cope with a family torn apart by grief and friends who turn their backs on her. But worst of all is the loss of her big sister, her confidante, her best friend, who has gone someplace no one can reach.

Selections from the auto-biographical verse novel: Stop Pretending by Sonya Sones

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My Sister's Christmas Eve Breakdown

(Pgs 4-5) One day
she was my big
sister, so normal and
well-behaved, the next she was a
stranger

rushing
out the door to
Midnight Mass, a wild-eyed
Jewish girl wearing only a
nightgown.

One day
he was my dad,
so calm and quiet and
in control, the next he was a
stranger

dragging
my big sister
away from the door, up

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the stairs, screaming so loud that my
ears stung.

One day
she was my mom,
so reliable and good in
a crisis, the next she was a
stranger

standing
stock still with her
hands clamped over her mouth
and her eyes squeezed shut, not even
breathing.

That day
I sank into
the wall, wondering what
these three people were doing in
my house

and I
shouted that they

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had to stop, even though
I wasn't supposed to talk to
strangers.

Three A.M. That Same Night

(Pgs 6-7) She hasn't gone to Mass,
hasn't gone to sleep,
hasn't stopped to catch her breath --
she can't stop talking.

She's showing me her stuff,
tons of stuff she bought,
stuff she bought this afternoon
when she went shopping.

Our bedroom's filled with bags,
way too many bags,
bags crammed full with too much stuff,
they're overflowing.

She's emptying them out:
fifty bars of soap,

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feather dusters, Ping-Pong balls,
a ski mask, fishbowls,

twelve pairs of sexy shoes
(the kind she never wears),
stationery monogrammed
with wrong initials.

I'm huddled on my bed,
wrapped up in my quilt,
listening to Sister rave
on and on and

just outside the door
angry whispers rise.
Trying not to let us hear,
our parents fight.

I'm huddled on my bed,
rocking in my quilt,
wishing I could fall asleep
and end this nightmare.

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[And then she was . . .]

Hospitalized

(Pg 9-10) Sister's in the psycho ward
and when I visit, I glance toward
the other patients' twisted faces,
quaking fingers,
frightened eyes,
wishing I could somehow break her out of here...

Then Sister starts to scream at Mother,
telling her how much she hates her,
begging her to stop the voices
chattering inside her skull.
I'm feeling sick,
the air's too thick...

Suddenly I'm running, stumbling,
Sister's demons chasing after,
leering, laughing,
right behind me
lurching at my heels
remind me:

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I could have been the one.

Run, Sister, run!

TRANSITION

*And as we all do when we run, we run to a place that feels safe. Sometimes it's not that we are running **from** something, but rather we are running **to** something. To a place of safety. For Sonya Somes, that safe place was a place of family. . . a place before. She found safety in her Midnight Swing.*

Midnight Swing

(Pg 17-18) When I can't fall asleep
I sneak out to the yard
and climb onto the swing
that's attached to a branch
of the sweet scented pine.

As I glide through the night
and I hang back my head
I see stars and a moon
that's following me
through the evergreen trees.

And I fly on my swing
through the midnight ice cold
as the swirling white clouds
of my own frozen breath
brush my tingling cheeks.

And my nightgown wafts up
and my hair billows out
as I float through the air
and there's only the sound
of the dark whooshing past.

And my thoughts drift to you
on a day long ago
when my legs were too short
so you helped me climb up
and you taught me to pump.

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TRANSITION

*But memories fade and reality tightens its grasp on our minds and souls very quickly. When you love someone who is suffering from a mental illness, it seems at times that you will never find them again; the **real** person -- a mother, a father, a sister who is drowning in a pool you cannot see. You talk, you love, you try, but you just can't reach them. It's like they don't even know you; and it's so easy to give up hope. But if you are patient and persevere . . . in many cases . . . finally*

Finally

(Pg 174) I fly home

from the hospital

to share the news

with my parents:

"She ***knew*** me today.

She knew who I was

and I knew her, too.

She was there. ***Really*** there.

We talked about dreams.

She braided my hair.

We sat side by side

and played 'Heart and Soul.'

Today, I hated to leave."

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I hug my parents

and they hug me back,

holding tight

like feathers to the wing of a bird.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Sonya Sones
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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier – MS
2019 National Qualifier – MS
2021 National Qualifier – MS
2023 National Qualifier – MS
2025 National Qualifier – MS
IL State Finalist
KS State Qualifier

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